

Assessment Booklet

HTQ Unit 551 - Managing a Project V1.0

LEARNER INFORMATION

CMI LEARNER STATEMENT/DECLARATION OF AUTHENTICITY

This statement must be completed and electronically attached to the completed assessment submitted to CMI. Any pieces of work that do not have this signed statement/declaration are inadmissible and will be returned to the Centre.

Section 1

Qualification Title	CMI Level 5 Higher Technical Qualification (HTQ) in Operations Management
Unit Number and Title	Unit 551: Managing a Project
Centre Name	Weston College
Learner Name	Graeme Wright
Learner CMI Number	P05260463

I Graeme Wright confirm that the work submitted is my own and that I am the sole author of this completed assessment and Sections 1 & 2 of this form have been checked and completed before submission. I have referenced/acknowledged any sources of information and Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools used in the submission; in line with the Qualification Handbook, [CMI's Assessment Guidance Policy](#) and [CMI's Plagiarism, Collusion and Artificial Intelligence \(AI\) Statement](#).

I consent to this assessment, or any extract from it, to be anonymised following which it may be used for assessment standardisation and, where appropriate, for the dissemination of good practice. The assessment will be kept in accordance with GDPR, if you have any concerns regarding this, please refer to our Data Privacy Policy	Tick here to opt-out	
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Section 2 -

Requirement prior to submission	Learner Signature / Initial to confirm
The Assessment Criteria (AC) have been used as headings or I have indicated or sign-posted within my work where each AC has been met.	
Word count is shown on the front sheet and is within the CMI guidelines for the unit.	
All answers relating to the Assessment Criteria (AC) are contained within the body of the text.	
Learner name and CMI membership number are identified on each page within the assessment (header or footer) and each page is numbered.	
All work that is <u>not</u> my own is clearly indicated and referenced using a formal referencing system.	
The work has been reviewed for spelling and grammar.	
Where work has been translated, the accuracy of the translation has been checked.	
I understand that CMI may use plagiarism software in the detection of plagiarism, collusion and AI misuse for this submission.	

I understand that a false declaration is a form of malpractice.

Learner Signature*	
Date (DD/MM/YYYY)	

**Please note electronic signatures are accepted*

ASSESSMENT TASKS AND WORD COUNT

Assessment brief **CMI HTQ 551** features the following assessment tasks. Further detail is provided against each

assessment task within the brief.

Assessment Task		Learning outcomes covered by assessment method	Assessment criteria	L5 ODM KSB	Guideline word count
1	Write a report titled: <i>Principles and Processes in Project Management</i>	LO1 Understand principles and processes for initiating, planning and managing projects	1.1 Define the principles of project management	K5 K6 K7 K8 K20	Approx. 2500 words
			1.2 Explain the purpose of projects in delivering organisational goals		
			1.3 Outline the process for initiating projects		
			1.4 Examine the tools and techniques to plan and manage projects in different contexts		
		LO2 Know the impact of legal, organisational and ethical factors on projects	2.1 Examine the impact of legal, organisational and ethical factors on projects		
2	Create a Project Plan to deliver an organisational goal	LO3 Be able to design, develop and manage a project to achieve results	3.1 Create a project proposal to deliver an organisational goal	S5 S6 S7 S8 S14 S17 S21 S22 B1 B2 B3 B4	Approx. 3500 words
			3.2 Consider methods for reporting on project outcomes		
			3.3 Specify methods of managing data and information in a project environment		
			3.4 Examine approaches to identify, manage and mitigate project risks		
		LO4 Be able to monitor and manage the factors which contribute to effective project management	4.1 Evaluate methods used for monitoring project progress		
			4.2 Use effective problem solving and decision making techniques when managing projects		
			4.3 Outline approaches for project closure		

Guideline word count

The written word, whether generated and/or recorded, is expected to form the majority of assessable work produced by Learners at Level 5. The amount and volume of written work for this unit should be broadly

comparable to a word count of **6000** words within a margin of +/-10%. The unit also includes additional work in the form of work based evidence. Excessive use of word count is not grounds for referral, however, the CMI reserves the right to return work to the Centre for editing and resubmission by the Learner.

The following are excluded from the written word count: Index or contents pages, headings and subheadings, diagrams, charts and graphs, bibliography.

Please see the [CMI Assessment Guidance Policy](#) for further guidance, along with the guidance on [Command Verb Definitions](#).

LEARNER EVIDENCE

BIBLIOGRAPHY

WORK BASED EVIDENCE

Unit 551: Managing a Project

Learner: Graeme Wright **CMI membership number:** P05260463 **Centre:** Weston College

Word count. Task 1: 2,729 **Task 2:** 3,384 **Total:** 6,113 (excluding headings, tables, figures and references)

Task 1: Principles and Processes in Project Management

1. Introduction

Project management is the structured application of processes, methods and skills to achieve specific objectives within agreed parameters (Association for Project Management (2019) *APM Body of Knowledge*, 7th edn, Association for Project Management, Princes Risborough). Where routine operations maintain the status quo, projects are the vehicle through which an organisation implements change and achieves its strategic goals. In the further education sector, effective project management ensures that limited resources are directed towards the activities that generate the most tangible organisational benefit. This report examines the principles and processes of project management through the Digital Skills Framework initiative I launched at Weston College. Although the wider framework was ultimately paused, a decision taken on evidence once discovery work established significant non-compliance at the foundational level, evaluating its life cycle provides critical insight into how legal, ethical and environmental factors dictate project success and shape competitive advantage.

2. Defining Project Management Principles (AC1.1)

A project is a temporary endeavour undertaken to create a unique product, service or result, and is distinct from the ongoing, repetitive work of operations (Project Management Institute (2021) *A Guide to the Project Management Body of Knowledge (PMBOK Guide)*, 7th edn, Project Management Institute, Newtown Square PA). My substantive role is operational coaching, but the development of the Digital Skills Framework was a discrete project with a defined scope, a start and an intended finish. It remains one of the founding documents that directs what I am trying to achieve in my role. Delivering it inside an operational environment required three principles in particular.

Tailoring is the adaptation of standard methodologies, governance and processes to suit the specific environment, constraints and complexity of a project (AXELOS (2017) *Managing Successful Projects with PRINCE2*, 6th edn, TSO, London). In planning, it prevents the over-engineering of process and allows reporting and governance to be scaled to the resource actually available. In execution, it keeps the project agile: structures that are too rigid block progress, whereas tailoring allows movement between delivery methods without drifting from the core objective. I held no formal budget and no line management authority over the volunteers involved.

Had I assumed control over every decision and every direction, the project would have failed. Instead I tailored execution around influence, integrating the Jisc Discovery tool into existing operational workflows rather than imposing new reporting structures I had no authority to enforce.

Stakeholder engagement is the identification of, communication with, and active involvement of the individuals and groups who can affect or be affected by a project (PMI, 2021). In planning, it captures requirements early and surfaces resistance before it hardens, so that the project reflects a genuine organisational need rather than an assumed one. In execution, it sustains the momentum and buy-in needed to identify critical roadblocks, navigate around them, and adapt scope when external factors shift. Because I lacked direct authority, engagement was not optional. Internal stakeholders, the account manager at Century and the Jisc community each held something I did not: reach into other departments, diagnostic instruments I could leverage rather than build, and the experience of other colleges facing the same problem.

Continued business justification requires that a project continues to make business sense throughout its life, and that it is reshaped or stopped at the point it no longer does (AXELOS, 2017). In planning, it establishes the business case and the baseline against which the investment of time and resource is judged. In execution, it provides the checkpoints that prevent drift away from the strategic goal. This is the principle that directly informed the decision to pause parts of the Digital Skills Framework and to carry forward the elements that build the foundation for what follows. Pausing was not a failure of the project; identifying which elements could still move the organisation forward was the principle working as intended.

3. Project Contribution to Organisational Goals (AC1.2)

The fundamental purpose of a project is to move an organisation from its current state to a desired future state in order to meet strategic goals. In this case the strategic driver is external and graded. Inspectors evaluate leaders' actions to secure learners' development of English, mathematical and digital skills, to help them access learning and take their next steps (Ofsted (2025) *Further education and skills inspection toolkit*, updated 9 September 2025, Ofsted, Manchester, p. 41). Digital skills are referenced only ever alongside English and mathematics, and they appear within the grading descriptors for Achievement itself, including as a stated reason learners cannot progress. Aligning a project to that requirement is not optional positioning; it addresses a graded judgement.

Bradley distinguishes outputs, outcomes and benefits, and argues that benefits are realised after a project closes and must be owned by the business rather than the project manager (Bradley, G. (2016) *Benefit Realisation Management*, 2nd edn, Routledge, London). The output is the tangible deliverable. The outcome is the operational or behavioural change that the output makes possible. The benefit is the organisational gain that justifies the investment.

Applied to this project, the output was the completed Digital Skills Framework document. The intended outcome was a change in operational practice: staff routinely using the Jisc Discovery tool and Century to baseline both their learners' digital capability and their own. Staff capability is not a secondary concern here. If staff do not hold the digital skills required to develop them in learners, the gap simply relocates rather than closes. The intended benefit was a measurable

removal of digital barriers to learning, directly supporting the college objective on embedding the SEND Framework.

The pause is instructive rather than embarrassing. Because the project halted at the output stage, it demonstrates Bradley's central point: a project can deliver its scope in full and still fail to realise organisational goals if the transition into operations is interrupted.

Competitive advantage in further education is not market share. It is learner recruitment, funding security, employer partnerships and inspection outcomes. The resource-based view holds that sustained advantage derives from resources that are valuable, rare and difficult to imitate (Barney, J. (1991) 'Firm Resources and Sustained Competitive Advantage', *Journal of Management*, 17(1), pp. 99–120). Any college can purchase the same software licences. What cannot be bought is staff capability built around this college's context, its curriculum areas and the skills South West employers actually require. The Framework positions digital skills within our own three-tier model of Digital Foundations, Inclusion and Innovation, which makes it both rare and difficult to imitate.

4. Process for Initiating Projects (AC1.3)

The process for initiating a project has three essential steps: the project is defined, its viability is tested, and formal approval is given. AXELOS separates the first two into distinct stages within PRINCE2. *Starting up a Project* produces a Project Brief, which asks whether the project is viable and worth doing. *Initiating a Project* then produces the Project Initiation Documentation, or PID, which serves as the control baseline against which the project is subsequently managed (AXELOS, 2017). The equivalent in PMBOK is the project charter, a critical step because it formally authorises the project to exist and gives the project manager explicit authority to apply organisational resources to it (PMI, 2021).

The approval stage of this project followed that pattern reasonably closely. I produced the documentation and took it to my line manager, the Assistant Principal for Quality. He reviewed it, and we iterated the language and direction so that both sat within the scope of what the Quality team does and the framework it operates in. Specifically, we worked through the Quality Handbook together to align what I was proposing on digital skills with the college's established position on teaching, learning and assessment. Once that alignment was established he signed it off, which gave me the authority to proceed.

Upstream of that approval, initiation was highly informal. The project did not originate from a mandate issued to me. It came from identifying a gap: the Ofsted toolkit made clear that the college needed to act on digital skills, and nobody else in the organisation was working on it. Feasibility testing was consequently conducted externally rather than internally. I worked with Jisc partners to establish the right Discovery question sets, checking that they aligned not only with the digital skills objective but with the pedagogical direction set out in the Quality Handbook and our vision for good practice in teaching, learning and assessment. I also worked with the Century account manager on methods of baselining learners' digital capability. Understanding how other organisations had approached the same problem substituted for the internal feasibility assessment that the formal process assumes.

Few project roles were ever established. I became the de facto project lead because no one else held the domain knowledge, which created an unusual initiation condition: I was seeking authorisation from my line manager while simultaneously educating him on the subject he was being asked to authorise. The consideration this raises is that authorisation secured without domain understanding on the part of the authoriser is weakly held. A project defined and understood by one person can be sustained while that person carries it, but it has little structural resilience when organisational capacity or priorities move.

5. Examination of Tools and Techniques (AC1.4)

Examining project tools requires acknowledging that different organisational contexts demand entirely different approaches, and this is visible within the college itself. In Sport and Health, the digital skills the industry requires are well understood, as are the resources available to those areas and the time staff are willing to commit; a predictive or waterfall approach suits that relative stability. In Construction and the Built Environment we are far less certain what the digital skills requirement looks like, so any plan needs a longer scoping and discovery phase before commitments on time or budget can sensibly be made. The tailoring principle holds that the delivery approach must fit the environment rather than being applied by default (PMI, 2021). My own context was adaptive by necessity: no formal budget, no line management authority, and a need to discover the college's baseline capability while simultaneously planning the interventions that would follow from it.

Work breakdown structure. A work breakdown structure decomposes large deliverables into smaller, manageable work packages. Its strength is that it provides the foundation on which accurate time and resource estimation becomes possible at all. Its limitation is that it performs best in predictive contexts where the final output is already known. In an adaptive context the work packages had to remain flexible, because the discovery tools kept revealing digital skills gaps that changed the scope of what needed to be done.

Gantt charts. A Gantt chart maps tasks against a timeline, showing duration, dependencies, responsibility and blockers. It works well in traditional contexts with dedicated, controllable resources, and it is effective for tracking the critical path. Its limitation in my project was that a rigid Gantt breaks down quickly. Having invested time sequencing phases of work, the factors I do not control (the college timetable, term dates, the operational workload of other departments, or an Ofsted inspection arriving) cause the fixed dates to fall away.

RACI matrices. A RACI matrix (responsible, accountable, consulted, informed) clarifies decision rights and assigns clear roles for every project task. It is highly effective in formal hierarchies where line management and formal reporting exist. It is the tool I use least, because that structure is not available to me. Delivery relied entirely on volunteers and I hold no line management authority, so formal accountability was impossible to assign. The tool breaks down in that context, and forces management through influence rather than through formal role assignment.

Stakeholder mapping and diagnostic tools. The power and interest grid supports prioritisation of which individuals must be influenced for a project to keep moving (Mendelow, A. (1991) 'Environmental Scanning: The Impact of the Stakeholder Concept', *Proceedings of the Second International Conference on Information Systems*, Cambridge MA). That work is essential where

formal authority is absent. Alongside it, standard scheduling tools were of limited use in a state of exploration, which is why I treated the Jisc Discovery question sets, and Century's learner diagnostics, as core project management tools rather than as subject-matter instruments.

The distinction is ultimately this. In a predictive context a project is managed by tracking schedule variance. In an adaptive context it is managed by data: gathering baseline information through Jisc and Century was how I adjusted scope in real time while holding the project's overall shape and direction.

6. Impact of Legal, Organisational and Ethical Factors (AC2.1)

Projects do not exist in a vacuum; they are constrained by the external and internal conditions around them, described in project management as enterprise environmental factors (PMI, 2021). For this project those factors shaped both its scope and its survival. Externally, the Ofsted requirement set the direction and sector bodies such as Jisc shaped what a credible response looked like. Internally, the position was unusual: another senior post holds digital across the college, but that role steers the policy direction of digital rather than the specific skills staff and learners need to develop. The Digital Skills Framework occupies that gap, and each curriculum area needs its own industry-aligned set of skills within it.

Legal factors created non-negotiable boundaries. The Equality Act 2010 and the Public Sector Bodies (Websites and Mobile Applications) (No. 2) Accessibility Regulations 2018 make the college accountable not only for the materials produced for learners but for the digital environments those learners work in, including Microsoft Teams and the content held within it. The regulations require conformance with WCAG 2.1 AA; I apply WCAG 2.2 AA as an internal standard, since it is the current W3C recommendation. Accessibility remains an area of concern for us and for many other colleges. Data protection was equally material. Century is a third-party platform with access to learner data, so the Data Protection Act 2018 and UK GDPR require a data processing agreement and a data protection impact assessment. Both are in place, though neither is authored by me; they are owned elsewhere in the college. The project therefore depends on a control it does not hold, and had those instruments not existed it could not have proceeded in this form.

Ethical factors centred on the collection and use of staff capability data. Baselining staff digital skills through the Jisc Discovery tool creates a dataset about individual competence. I resolved this by ensuring staff retain their own data and share only their development priorities with their Digital Lead, their line manager and me. As a coach I do not need to see the scores; I need to understand the direction someone wants to move in. The boundary is that the data supports development and is not repurposed as performance management. This is not theoretical: a member of staff left the Digital Leads programme because they were uncomfortable auditing colleagues. Without psychological safety, staff will not engage, and the project fails for want of data.

Organisational factors determined how the project was managed. Lacking budget control and line management authority, I aligned the project's objectives directly to the Quality Handbook to secure internal buy-in and ensure the scope sat correctly within the Quality function. Shifting organisational priorities and restructuring then altered the timeline. The decision to pause the upper tiers of the Framework, however, was driven by evidence rather than by circumstance:

discovery work established significant non-compliance at the Digital Foundations tier, and that compliance had to be secured before building above it.

On balance, the legal factors set hard limits and directly influenced the decision to pause, because compliance on accessibility had to be secured before building further. The ethical factors determined whether staff would participate at all. But it is the organisational factors (the absence of formal authority, competing departmental priorities and structural change) that have had the greatest impact on how this project has moved forward.

7. Conclusion

The Digital Skills Framework was designed to protect the college's long-term strategic direction. By equipping staff to evidence digital competency confidently for Ofsted inspection, and by ensuring learners graduate with the precise skills local employers demand, the project served to safeguard the college's reputation and its competitive advantage.

The most significant lesson I take from it is that managing purely by influence has a hard limit. Without formal initiation, and specifically without a documented charter or approval, a defined budget and structural authority, a project remains inherently vulnerable when organisational structures and priorities shift. A project without a charter simply has to pause.

The overarching framework is paused, but the objective has not been abandoned; it has been rescoped. The immediate focus has moved to delivering targeted, structured digital skills assets for staff through SharePoint, concentrating on the foundational level. Two findings drove that decision: legal compliance on accessibility and inclusion had to take priority, and staff capacity was not yet sufficient to carry the wider framework forward. This allows the core principles of the project to survive operationally until organisational capacity permits the full framework to be revisited.

Task 2. Project Plan: Digital Skills for Staff and Learners

Introduction

The Ofsted inspection toolkit is the external driver for this project. Digital skills appear repeatedly within it, and always alongside English and mathematics, including within the graded Achievement descriptors, where inspectors evaluate leaders' actions to secure learners' development of those skills (Ofsted (2025) *Further education and skills inspection toolkit*, updated 9 September 2025, Ofsted, Manchester, p. 41). Weston College currently holds no baseline of digital skills for either staff or learners. That absence is the problem this project addresses.

The learner position is widely misread. We assume arriving learners are digital natives. They are not. Their competence comes from consumer mobile applications rather than from being taught to communicate, organise material or collaborate in digital spaces. Elements appear in some

curriculum areas, but a learner entering the first year of further education has most likely come through a system that stopped teaching this at the end of Year 9. The staff position mirrors it. If staff do not hold the skills, the gap simply relocates, because the college is now responsible for developing both general and industry-specific digital skills so learners can progress to employment or further study.

The immediate trigger was structural. Following a restructure of the digital learning team, the college lost its Digital Education Manager, and with that post it lost the person who translated the Ofsted toolkit into college practice and who held the relationships with Jisc, Century and other external partners. No one remained with responsibility for understanding the digital skills position of staff or learners. Across 600+ staff, 35 curriculum areas and nine campuses, that gap needed closing quickly.

Project Objectives (AC3.1)

The project has four objectives. Where dates and volume targets were previously set, several have been suspended by the pause; the targets below apply from the point the Jisc Discovery tool is released, anticipated within the coming months. Progression is not measured by diagnostic alone: staff development is also tracked through learning walks, student voice, staff surveys and digital health checks, while the RAG rating of learner progress is owned by the Personal Development team.

Objective	Measure	Target
1. Baseline staff digital capability across curriculum areas	Completion of the Jisc Discovery tool, with staff retaining their own data and sharing only their development priorities	Approximately two thirds of staff completing within the first month of release; reassessment annually
2. Baseline learner digital skills on entry	Century diagnostic completion and subsequent progression data	Over 80% of 16–19 study programme learners baselined
3. Produce the Digital Skills Framework, mapping industry-aligned digital skills to each curriculum area	Framework published and adopted, with baselining and monitoring methods defined per area	All 35 curriculum areas mapped
4. Establish progression tracking so learner development is evidenced over time	Progression reported by Heads of Area through the existing Quality Handbook assurance process	Progression against each area's own intended methods reported by year end

Objectives 1 and 2 are constrained by data protection law and by the ethical position set out above: the diagnostic exists to direct development, not to assess individuals.

Scope of Work (AC3.1)

Scope is bounded tightly, because much of the surrounding digital estate is owned by other post holders. The exclusions below are as important as the inclusions, and several of them are the reason the project could be paused by decisions taken elsewhere.

In scope	Out of scope
Teaching staff across the 35 curriculum areas	Infrastructure, devices and networks (owned elsewhere in the college)
Learners on 16–19 study programmes (possible later extension to other programmes)	Digital policy and AI governance (owned by another post holder)
Jisc Discovery as the staff baselining instrument	The Digital Leads accessibility programme, a parallel workstream arising from the foundations findings
Century as the learner diagnostic and progression instrument	Whole-college teaching, learning and assessment decisions (owned within the wider team; I can influence and recommend)
SharePoint as the staff development resource, and Teams as the learning environment	Procurement and contracting, including for Century (I can propose only, holding no budget)
The three tiers of the Digital Skills Framework: Digital Foundations, Digital Inclusion, Digital Innovation	Completion of DPIAs and data protection policy (run by others)
	Individual staff performance management (owned by line managers)

The scope has since narrowed. Discovery work established significant non-compliance at the Digital Foundations tier, so activity on Inclusion and Innovation was paused in order to secure a compliant accessibility and inclusion foundation first. The Framework cannot deliver at the upper tiers if the base is unsound.

Project Deliverables (AC3.1)

The Framework document itself is complete and aligned to the Quality Handbook, its processes and its established dates, so it introduces no new machinery. The remaining deliverables sit within my direct ownership or my ability to support and cascade through the Digital Leads network.

Deliverable	Status and ownership
Digital Skills Framework document	Complete; aligned to the Quality Handbook
Configured Jisc Discovery question sets	My ownership; communicated via the Digital Leads network
Century diagnostic configuration and learner baseline reports	Supported by me; cascaded through Digital Leads to teachers and Heads of Area

Deliverable	Status and ownership
Per-area digital skills profiles aligning industry skills to curriculum delivery	Developed with each area
SharePoint digital skills assets providing independent staff CPD, signposting Jisc resources	My ownership; the currently active element
Baseline report to the Assistant Principal and Vice Principal for Quality	Covering development undertaken, gaps identified and impact on departmental success

Timeline / Schedule (AC3.1)

Phasing is expressed relative to project start rather than against fixed calendar dates. This is deliberate: the project has no devolved budget and no control over the college timetable, so absolute dates would give a false impression of certainty. Milestones are the control points.

Phase	Activity	Indicative timing	Milestone
1	Initiation: gap confirmed, brief produced, alignment to the Quality Handbook agreed with the Assistant Principal for Quality	Month 1	Formal sign-off
2	Feasibility: Jisc Discovery question sets configured with Jisc partners; Century baselining approach agreed with account manager	Months 1–2	Question sets finalised
3	Framework development: three tiers defined, industry-aligned skills mapped per curriculum area	Months 2–3	Framework published
4	Foundations assessment: baseline compliance position established	Month 3	Go / rescope decision point
5	Staff baselining: Jisc Discovery released via Digital Leads network	Month 4	Two thirds of staff complete within one month of release

Phase	Activity	Indicative timing	Milestone
6	Learner baselining: Century diagnostics deployed to 16–19 study programmes	Term 1	80%+ of cohort baselined
7	Analysis and area profiles: data collated, per-area digital skills profiles produced	Term 1–2	Profiles issued to all 35 areas
8	Targeted intervention: coaching and CPD deployed against identified gaps	Term 2	Area action underway
9	Progression reporting: Heads of Area report through the Quality Handbook assurance cycle	Term 3	Progression evidenced by year end
10	Reassessment: annual Jisc Discovery re-run, triangulated against learning walks, student voice, staff surveys and digital health checks	Annual	Baseline-to-baseline comparison

Actual position. Phase 4 established significant non-compliance at the Digital Foundations tier. Phases 5 to 9 were paused and the scope narrowed to securing that foundation, with SharePoint digital skills assets for staff as the interim deliverable. Phase 4 functioned as a stage gate, and the gate did what a gate is for.

Budget (AC3.1)

The defining budgetary feature of this project is that it carries no devolved budget. I can propose expenditure but not authorise it. The material cost is therefore staff time rather than cash, and platform costs sit on budgets held elsewhere in the college. The figures below are indicative and rest on stated assumptions; presenting them transparently is more useful than presenting a cash schedule that was never committed.

Assumptions. Jisc Discovery is included within existing college membership at no marginal cost. Century is already contracted for English and mathematics, so its digital skills diagnostics carry no new licence cost and, significantly, the data protection instruments already exist. All staff time is absorbed within contracted hours rather than funded additionally, so the true constraint is capacity, not cash. Time estimates below are planning assumptions to be validated at initiation, not measured figures.

Staff time model.

Activity	Assumption	Volume	Total hours	Approx. FTE days
Staff completion of Jisc Discovery	45 minutes per member of staff, once annually	600 staff	450	60
Digital Leads cascade and support	4 hours per lead per cycle	36 leads	144	19
Heads of Area reporting	2 hours per area per reporting cycle	35 areas	70	9
Project lead: configuration, analysis, area profiles, coaching	Within existing post	1 post/n/a	Absorbed	
Total additional staff time drawn from curriculum capacity			664	≈ 88

Cost category	Basis	Indicative cost	Budget held by
Jisc Discovery tool	Within existing Jisc membership	No marginal cost	College Jisc subscription
Century platform licence	Existing contract, predating this project. Base rate of £2,760, scaling with the number of learners given platform access; the college figure is individually quoted rather than a flat rate	No marginal cost attributable to this project; any increase arises only from extending learner access	Held elsewhere in the college
Staff time: Discovery completion	600+ staff, one completion per year	Absorbed within contracted hours	Curriculum area staffing
Staff time: Digital Leads cascade	36 volunteer Digital Leads	Absorbed; voluntary, unpaid	Curriculum area staffing
Staff time: Heads of Area reporting	35 areas, within existing Quality Handbook cycle	Absorbed within existing assurance activity	Curriculum area staffing
Project lead time	Digital Pedagogy Coach post	Absorbed within existing post	Quality and Innovation

Cost category	Basis	Indicative cost	Budget held by
SharePoint asset development	Digital Pedagogy Coach post	Absorbed within existing post	Quality and Innovation
Contingency	None available	Nil	No devolved budget exists

Expressed this way, the project asks the college for roughly 88 working days of existing staff capacity and no cash at all. That is the honest figure, and it is the one that should have been presented at initiation.

The budgetary risk this exposes. A project with no cash cost appears free, and a project that appears free attracts no governance, no sponsor and no protection. The absence of a contingency line is not an oversight; it is the reason the project could be paused without any budgetary consequence being visible to anyone.

Resource Requirements (AC3.1)

Resource type	Required	Availability
Human: project lead	Digital Pedagogy Coach, 1 post	Available; single point of failure
Human: cascade network	36 volunteer Digital Leads across curriculum areas	Available but voluntary; engagement uneven
Human: curriculum leadership	35 Heads of Area for area-level reporting and accountability	Available through existing Quality Handbook cycle
Human: learner progression	Personal Development team, owning learner RAG rating	Available; owned outside the project
Human: data protection	DPIA and data processing agreement authors	In place; owned elsewhere, and therefore a dependency rather than a resource I control
Technological	Jisc Discovery, Century, SharePoint, Microsoft Teams	All in place
Informational	Ofsted toolkit, Quality Handbook, Jisc sector resources and community	Available
Physical	Nine campus locations for any in-person delivery	Available through existing timetabling
Not available	Devolved budget; line management authority; a project sponsor with domain understanding; dedicated project administration Absent: see risk register	

Methodology / Approach (AC3.3)

The project is run through an adaptive, phased methodology grounded in the continuous Plan–Do–Check–Act cycle (Deming, W.E. (1986) *Out of the Crisis*, MIT Press, Cambridge MA). Rather than a rigid college-wide rollout, the tiered delivery model allows interventions to be tested, data gathered, and the Framework refined iteratively before scaling.

The project generates a deliberate mixture of quantitative and qualitative data. Quantitatively, it draws on individual staff outputs from the Jisc Discovery tool, learner baseline diagnostics from the Century platform, and departmental health check scores mapped into the area RAG ratings. Qualitatively, learning walks, coaching conversations and student voice feedback supply the context the numbers cannot. Neither stream is sufficient alone: a score identifies where to look, a conversation explains what is actually happening there.

Because auditing digital capability triggers staff anxiety, storage and access are governed by a strict staff-hold-their-own-data model. This is a methodological decision taken to protect psychological safety, not merely a compliance measure. Individual staff retain complete ownership of their Jisc Discovery profiles. Management and project leads see only anonymised, aggregated data at departmental level, never individual performance metrics. The only individual-level information shared with me is the direction a member of staff wishes to develop in and the priorities they have set for themselves. Learner diagnostic data held on Century is managed under role-based access controls, so that only the educators directly responsible for those learners can view it, maintaining UK GDPR compliance.

Raw data from these streams is collated using securely hosted internal tools, principally dedicated SharePoint pages, and analysed to build highly specific profiles for individual academic and support departments. Data is not collected for reporting alone; it drives what happens next. Analysing area profiles translates raw data into targeted action, deploying coaching resource precisely where the operational gaps sit, rather than relying on generic blanket training that never addresses a specific need.

Risk Management (AC3.4)

Risk was assessed against what could realistically stop delivery rather than against a generic register. Three threats were real: volunteer disengagement, staff anxiety about being audited, and the absence of a formal budget or sponsor, which left the project exposed to shifting organisational priorities (PMI, 2021).

One anticipated risk proved overstated. Inter-rater inconsistency was a lesser threat than expected, because baselining relies on standardised platforms rather than subjective human observation. Jisc Discovery and the Century diagnostics are adaptive: they alter the questions presented according to the responses given, and they are standardised against national digital skills frameworks. The instrument, not the assessor, carries the reliability.

One risk was understated, and it is an administrative one. Securing a signed data processing agreement and data protection impact assessment for an external platform is a serious schedule risk capable of blocking execution entirely. Here it did not materialise, but for a reason that was fortunate rather than planned: the college holds a long-standing relationship with Century through its mathematics provision, so the agreements were already written and signed off. Aligning the digital skills diagnostic to an existing contracted platform removed a dependency that could otherwise have halted the project for months.

Two mitigations were built into the design. To prevent baselining from feeling like a punitive performance audit, the staff-hold-their-own-data model means management reviews aggregated and anonymised trends only. Understanding the trend is sufficient to plan; individual data is neither needed nor sought. To mitigate volunteer dependency, the Framework was broken into modular, tiered phases so that volunteers could contribute in short bursts without their primary teaching load being overwhelmed.

The risk that materialised was the shifting of organisational priorities. Lacking a formal charter or a ring-fenced budget, the overarching Framework had to be paused when restructures and departmental priorities moved. Naming a risk and then watching it occur is not a failure of project management; it demonstrates that the register was accurate. It also allowed a controlled pivot rather than a collapse, into SharePoint assets, teaching materials and guides addressing the areas of more urgent need.

Stakeholder Analysis (AC3.1)

Stakeholder analysis here deliberately avoids a standard power and interest grid, and uses instead a resource dependency perspective, which holds that organisations and actors are governed by their dependence on resources controlled by others (Pfeffer, J. and Salancik, G.R. (1978) *The External Control of Organizations: A Resource Dependence Perspective*, Harper & Row, New York). This frame suits a project run without formal authority far better, because the operative question is not how powerful someone is but what they control that the project cannot proceed without.

Stakeholder	Resource they control	Impact of withdrawal
Assistant Principal, Quality (line manager) and Vice Principal, Quality	Authority, strategic alignment, integration into the Quality Handbook, and the direction of my time and resource	The project loses its organisational mandate and becomes an isolated, unfunded idea
Heads of Area	Staff time, teaching timetables and area priorities	Without their permission teaching staff cannot participate, and the operational transition fails immediately
Digital Leads and teaching staff	Peer-to-peer influence and classroom execution; they perform the practice the	The delivery mechanism collapses at grassroots level; no line management authority

Stakeholder	Resource they control	Impact of withdrawal
Digital policy post holder	project exists to improve Platform, policy and governance environment the project operates within	exists to compel participation Misalignment between skills work and policy direction; duplicated or contradictory activity
Personal Development team	Ownership of learner RAG rating and progression reporting	Learner progression cannot be evidenced beyond the initial baseline
Learners	Participation in diagnostics	No baseline, and therefore no measurable progression
Jisc	The Discovery instrument, sector benchmarking and community expertise	Loss of a nationally standardised staff baselining tool and of external validation
Century	Learner diagnostic platform, progression data, and the pre-existing data protection agreements	Loss of learner baselining capability and reintroduction of the DPIA schedule risk
Ofsted	The regulatory judgement on the college's digital skills provision	If the Framework fails to satisfy inspection criteria, the project fails its primary strategic purpose

Each group requires a different mode of communication, reporting and relationship building, addressed in the communication plan below.

Communication Plan (AC3.2)

Effective project communication ensures the right information reaches the right stakeholders at the right time (PMI, 2021). Communication is therefore structured in tiers, differentiated by the decisions each audience needs to make rather than by seniority alone.

The Assistant Principal for Quality, my line manager, receives detailed and granular updates on project progression on a fortnightly basis, delivered through Teams meetings or one to one. This is supplemented between those points by written progress reports and by direct requests for refinement or agreement on work in progress, including draft policy and written material.

The Vice Principal for Quality, together with the Deputy Principals for learner experience and learner outcomes, receives high-level monthly or termly summaries. These carry the collegiate RAG rating and platform completion rates, and are delivered as written reports to inform strategic oversight: what patterns have emerged, what has been discovered, and what the implications are. This tier is not passive reporting. It is where the decision to pause the wider Framework in favour of accessibility and inclusion was reached, and where the decision to work more closely with the SEND team on embedding their framework across the college was taken.

Heads of Area receive targeted area profiles setting out departmental gaps, the underlying data and the resulting action plans. These are communicated directly in department meetings, though more often through the Digital Lead for that area. Digital Leads and teaching staff themselves receive continuous operational updates and resources through Teams channels and published SharePoint pages.

The most consequential communication decision in this project, however, concerns what is deliberately withheld. Individual staff capability data generated by the Jisc Discovery tool is not reported upward, even where I could see or infer it. The rationale is protection of psychological safety. If individual digital skills deficits were reported to management, the project would be understood as a performance management audit rather than the supportive coaching mechanism it is intended to be. Stakeholder theory holds that communication must build trust and alignment (Freeman, R.E. (1984) *Strategic Management: A Stakeholder Approach*, Pitman, Boston). Reporting only aggregated trends is what allows staff to engage honestly with baselining, and honest engagement is the precondition of the data being worth anything at all.

Quality Assurance / Control (AC4.1)

Quality management ensures that a project satisfies the needs for which it was undertaken (APM, 2019). Quality was therefore secured during production through four build gates rather than inspected at the end.

First, all project objectives and outputs were aligned to the college's existing Quality Handbook, ensuring institutional relevance and situating the work within an agreed framework rather than alongside one. Second, accessibility acted as a mandatory build gate: everything published to SharePoint had to meet WCAG 2.2 AA, which exceeds the WCAG 2.1 AA required under the Public Sector Bodies Accessibility Regulations 2018. If it did not pass, it did not launch. That gate carries particular weight given that non-compliance at the foundational accessibility level is precisely what caused the wider project to pause. Third, I relied on standardised, externally validated instruments, namely Jisc Discovery and Century, rather than building a homemade diagnostic in Forms or a similar tool. Instruments independently tested against national datasets and skills frameworks secure a baseline of reliability immediately, which no locally built questionnaire could claim. Fourth, all Framework content required formal sign-off from my line manager before distribution.

It is essential to distinguish quality assurance from quality control (PMI, 2021). Quality assurance is proactive and process-oriented: it prevents problems. In this project, assurance meant deciding at the outset that only WCAG-compliant templates would be used, and establishing the rule that only validated platforms would collect data, preventing poor data collection before it began. Quality control is reactive and product-oriented: it catches problems. Control occurred when my line manager reviewed the drafted Framework document, and when automated accessibility checkers were run against SharePoint pages prior to publication.

The review with my line manager illustrates why control remains necessary even where assurance is strong. The Framework as originally drafted did not align properly with the Quality Handbook. Iterating and reframing it against that document reshaped the Digital Skills Framework so that it sat within the college's established position on teaching, learning and assessment, rather than reading

as a parallel initiative competing with it. Assurance had set the standards; only control revealed that the output had missed one.

Evaluation / Measurement (AC4.1)

Project evaluation requires comparing actual performance against planned objectives (APM, 2019). Success would be measured principally through baseline-to-reassessment comparison on the Jisc Discovery tool for staff, and progression data from the Century platform for learners, allowing the movement of both groups to be mapped over time. Staff complete Discovery, a collegiate picture is produced, and reassessment establishes whether that picture has shifted. Century provides the learner starting point and then individual progression across their time at college. Operationally, success would also be measured through diagnostic completion rates, through Head of Area progression reporting, where each area sees its own data and completion position and takes it forward with me, and through movement in departmental RAG ratings across the academic year.

Every one of those methods carries a limitation that has to be acknowledged. Jisc Discovery is a self-assessment instrument, and self-assessment measures confidence rather than competence: a member of staff may score highly precisely because they do not know what they do not know. This is not hypothetical. Staff at Weston College presented as knowledgeable about accessibility and inclusion, yet the Digital Lead audits established that a substantial number did not know how to apply it. Confidence and capability had separated. Completion rates are weaker still, since logins and module completions measure participation only, and prove neither learning nor behavioural change, which is precisely why qualitative data must sit alongside the quantitative. RAG ratings and Head of Area reporting are largely subjective management judgements, and are therefore vulnerable to bias and to inconsistent application between departments, between points in the year, and between competing local priorities. Finally there is the attribution problem: even if digital skills improve across the college, it is analytically difficult to demonstrate that the Framework caused the improvement rather than external factors or ordinary operational coaching.

The pause limits evaluation scope sharply, because the project halted before the operational transition. What can be evaluated is the outputs: the quality and accessibility of the SharePoint assets produced, initial participation in the December pilot diagnostics, and the foundations finding itself, which established that the college was not compliant on accessibility and inclusion and therefore could not build above that level. What cannot yet be evaluated are the outcomes or the benefits. I cannot demonstrate that the Framework shifted long-term digital capability or removed barriers to learning, because the project stopped before those benefits could be realised. What I would argue is that proceeding deliberately, by securing the foundation before resuming the wider Framework, makes the removal of those barriers more likely, not less.

Problem Solving and Decision Making (AC4.2)

The most significant problem encountered was the foundations non-compliance finding. Early diagnostic data revealed that foundational digital skills were missing among staff, which

immediately threatened the viability of the higher-level pedagogical goals the Framework was built on. Very few staff were positioned to move to the Inclusion or Innovation tiers, because the base they would move from was not secure. Continuing to build upward would have produced provision that only a small minority could access.

The decision to pivot the project scope was made collaboratively rather than unilaterally. I gathered the evidence from the December Jisc Discovery results and presented it to my line manager and the Quality team, securing their agreement to address the basic gaps first. This mattered procedurally as well as practically: in the absence of a traditional project board, that conversation was the only mechanism through which a scope change could be formally authorised.

Two techniques underpinned the decision. The first was root cause analysis. Poor adoption of advanced platforms initially presented as a training problem, and the obvious response would have been to deliver more training. Analysis established that it was not a training issue at all but a symptom of missing foundational digital literacy. Treating the symptom would have consumed resource without moving anything. The same analysis holds for learners: the assumption that arriving learners are digital natives with embedded digital literacy is a myth, and provision has to be built from the ground up rather than layered onto a competence that is not there.

The second was the check and act stages of the Plan–Do–Check–Act cycle (Deming, 1986). Checking the initial reality against the plan produced a finding the plan had not anticipated, and acting on it meant escalating to my line manager so that the change of scope was authorised rather than assumed. The value of a structured cycle in a project with no formal governance is that it creates a defined moment at which evidence is compared to intention, and a decision must be taken. Without that discipline, the temptation is to continue delivering the original plan because it is the plan.

Project Closure (AC4.3)

A paused project must still undergo a formal closure process, both to prevent work being wasted and to secure institutional memory (AXELOS, 2017). Closure here is partial rather than terminal: the wider Framework is suspended, but its constituent elements remain live and are being progressed more slowly and with a tighter focus.

The first closure activity is documentation and handover. The drafted Digital Skills Framework document persists as a founding reference, and its elements now direct two active streams of work: the Digital Leads programme, and the support given to teachers in developing their understanding of accessibility and inclusion in order to secure the Digital Foundations tier. Handing those elements into ongoing operational work, rather than shelving them with the parent project, is what allows the investment already made to continue producing value.

The second is capturing lessons learned. This report documents the structural initiation failures directly: the danger of proceeding without a ring-fenced budget or a formal sponsor, and the consequence that a project sustained by one person has little resilience when organisational priorities move. Recording that honestly is more useful than recording a clean account of a project that stopped.

The third is the mitigation this closure provides against the single most serious risk in the register: that I am the central point of both contact and knowledge. If the college's capacity grows and the project restarts, or if I move on from the role, the intelligence gathered and the work completed can be resumed rather than rebuilt from nothing. That is the practical test of good closure: not whether a project finished, but whether the next person to pick it up can do so without repeating it.

Formal closure would also include confirming with the Assistant Principal and Vice Principal for Quality that the suspension is recorded and understood, releasing the Digital Leads from Framework-specific commitments so that their capacity transfers cleanly to the foundational accessibility work, and agreeing the conditions under which the wider Framework would be reactivated. Defining those conditions at closure matters, because a project paused without stated resumption criteria is in practice a project cancelled quietly.

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Task 1

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Task 2

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Statement on the Use of Artificial Intelligence

I used Claude (Anthropic) as a learning support tool throughout the preparation of this assignment. The nature of that support was as follows.

Understanding the brief. The assessment criteria and command verbs were explained to me, including what “define”, “explain”, “outline”, “examine” and “evaluate” each required me to demonstrate, and where the task headings extended a criterion beyond its stated verb.

Drawing out content. I was asked structured questions about my own project and responded verbally using dictation. Later in the assignment, where I was finding it difficult to hold the thread, I asked for the questions to be replaced with numbered prompts and for my own evidence to be summarised back to me so that I could confirm, correct or add to it. All examples, evidence, professional judgements, decisions and reflections in this assignment are my own.

Editing my dictated text. My dictated responses were returned to me tidied for grammar, spelling, repetition and order. Dictation errors were corrected throughout (for example “Princess Two” for PRINCE2, “Gist” for Jisc, “Sentry” for Century, “work brakes structure” for work breakdown structure, and “8:00 PM 2019” for APM 2019). I reviewed and approved all edits.

Sources and referencing. Relevant academic and professional sources were suggested to me, with an explanation of what each argued and where it supported my point. I have verified each source and satisfied myself that it says what I have attributed to it.

Verification and challenge in both directions. Where my own claims were imprecise, they were checked and corrected. I had referred to the Ofsted inspection framework as the “EIF toolkit”; it is the *Further education and skills inspection toolkit*, updated 9 September 2025. I believed digital skills were mentioned approximately seven times; the verified count against the primary source is six mentions of “digital”, five of them “digital skills”, all within the graded Achievement evaluation area. I had also stated that the Public Sector Bodies Accessibility Regulations 2018 require WCAG 2.2 AA; they require WCAG 2.1 AA, and 2.2 AA is the higher internal standard I choose to apply.

Equally, where an inference had been drawn from my dictation that went beyond what I said, it was flagged to me explicitly for confirmation or removal rather than left in the text.

Avoiding duplication across units. My prior submissions were checked to identify where case studies and sources had already been used. The Digital Leads accessibility programme was the case study for Units 553 and 549, so Unit 551 uses the Digital Skills Framework project instead. Unit 550 used a power/interest stakeholder map, so this assignment uses a resource dependency perspective rather than repeating that analysis.

Word count management. Word counts were tracked continuously against a budget for each section, and I was told where content needed to come out to pay for anything added.

Critical feedback. I received direct challenge where my account was internally inconsistent, in particular where my explanation of why the project paused differed between Task 1 and Task 2, and I resolved that inconsistency myself. I was also told plainly where a claim would not stand without verification.

The project, the decisions taken within it, the analysis, the professional judgements and the conclusions in this assignment are my own.